South Africans would pick off singles to third man. Three or four singles an over would really ease the pressure on them in a relatively low-scoring contest. I wasn't worried about Robin bowling a leg-stump wide, just as long as he didn't pitch the ball outside off stump. I was confident that the South Africans were not prepared for this strategy. Robin did his job well. He bowled his full quota of ten overs, giving away only 40 runs and also picking up the important wickets of Hansie Cronje and Daryll Cullinan.

The Test series that followed the Titan Cup was always going to be fiercely competitive. South Africa were one of the better teams at the time and had fast bowlers of the calibre of Allan Donald and Fanie de Villiers and batsmen of the class of Cronje, Gary Kirsten, Daryll Cullinan and Jonty Rhodes. The first match of the series at Ahmedabad started on 20 November 1996 and was a great contest, with multiple twists and turns. After we were bowled out for a modest 223 in the first innings, South Africa managed a handy 21-run lead. It was a good lead in the context of what seemed likely to be a low-scoring game and we had to bat well in the second innings to set them a reasonable target. We faltered and left South Africa needing just 170 to win in a little under two days.

The game wasn't lost yet, however. There was a lot of wear and tear on the pitch by the end of the third day and we knew that 170 might prove tricky on that surface. We were playing two leg-spinners in Anil Kumble and Narendra Hirwani and a left-arm spinner in Sunil Joshi. The South Africans would undoubtedly expect me to attack them with spinners on a crumbling pitch. Instead, I decided to use Javagal Srinath, because Sri, with his extra pace, could also get the ball to reverse-swing. Swing at a good pace is very difficult to deal with and in no time Srinath had given us a dream start, reducing the South Africans to 0–2.

After his successful short opening burst, I rested Srinath for a while before bringing him back for another long spell. I kept talking to him to check if he was feeling tired. He was bowling beautifully and had the batsmen in all sorts of trouble. I put Sunil Joshi on at the other end to keep the batsmen in check and not concede too many runs. I asked Sunil to pitch the ball in the rough outside the left-handers' off stump and keep them tied down to one end. This was to allow Srinath to bowl to the right-handers, as reverse swing was more effective against right-handed batsmen. This move paid real dividends. Sunil managed to stem the run